

BELGIUM



THIS SMALL, DENSELY POPULATED country in northwest Europe borders France, Germany, and the Netherlands. Its current borders were settled in 1919, after World War I (1914–18). Today, Belgium is a highly developed industrial nation with a thriving economy. As a founder member of the European Union since 1957, and of the Benelux alliance (with the Netherlands and Luxembourg), Belgium plays an important role in European and international affairs.

Physical features

In the north of Belgium is a flat plain stretching from Flanders to the Dutch border. The central plateau is bounded to the south by the Meuse and Sambre rivers. The Ardennes Plateau extends into Luxembourg and France.

Ardennes Plateau

The Ardennes Plateau covers 10,000 sq km (3,860 sq miles) in southern Belgium, Luxembourg, and northern France. Crossed by deep river valleys such as the Semois and Meuse, this upland area is rocky and heavily wooded and has spectacular limestone caves.



BELGIUM FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Brussels
AREA	32,820 sq km (12,672 sq miles)
POPULATION	10,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Dutch, French, German
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Euro
LIFE EXPECTANCY	78 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	294
GOVERNMENT	Multi-party democracy
ADULT LITERACY	99%



River Meuse

The Meuse flows slowly through gentle farmland and steep-sided valleys for 950 km (590 miles) from its source in France, west to east across Belgium, to the Dutch coast.



Brussels

With about a million inhabitants, Belgium's capital, Brussels, is the centre of government and trade. With three languages – Dutch, French, and German – it is a truly international city and the administrative headquarters of the European Union.



Gothic buildings in Brussels' Grand Place

Industry

Belgium has highly developed business and service industries, such as banking and insurance. The once-thriving coal and steel industries on the rivers Meuse and Sambre are now in crisis and are being rapidly replaced by new industries producing pharmaceuticals, chemicals, electrical equipment, and textiles. Belgium is one of the world's largest exporters of chocolate, and produces fine beers.



Belgian chocolates

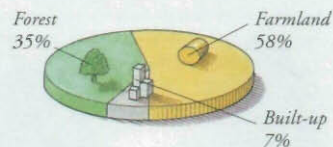


Climate

The Belgian climate is generally mild, but the skies are often cloudy. Rainfall is plentiful, especially in the mountains of the Ardennes where winter snow lingers. Summers tend to be short.

Land use

Much of Belgium is built-up and densely populated. Farmers produce cereals, fruit, vegetables, and sugar beet and raise cattle, sheep, and horses. Belgium has few natural resources and uses over 60 per cent nuclear power.



People

In southern Belgium people speak Walloon, a dialect of French. In the north people speak Dutch, formerly called Flemish. A few people in the east speak German.



Luxembourg

This tiny country shares borders with Belgium, Germany, and France. Its people enjoy low unemployment and Europe's highest living standards. It is known as a banking centre.



Finance centre

Despite its tiny size, Luxembourg is a key member of the European Union. The headquarters of the European Parliament and the European Court of Justice are based in Luxembourg City.

LUXEMBOURG FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Luxembourg
AREA	2,585 sq km (998 sq miles)
POPULATION	431,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	French, German, Letzeburgish
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Euro